CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

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RE: PNG plays down Taiwan office closure · Marshall Islands warns COP31 on overshoot · Nauru left without an opposition · Burke reworks backpacker crackdown · Albanese-Chalmers rift fuels Labor reset talk

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
9,082	0.6782	14,174	0.5529
+0.68%	-1.27%	+1.25%	-0.52%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · AUKUS · Pacific · New Zealand · Canberra · Markets · Upcoming · The Wire

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. Papua New Guinea's foreign minister played down the closure of Taiwan's office in the country, saying it will not affect the economy.
2. Home Affairs Minister Tony Burke confirmed Canberra is reworking its working holiday visa crackdown while still seeking to cut the number of British backpackers staying up to three years under the 2023 free trade deal.
3. The President of the Marshall Islands told COP31 the response to Paris Agreement overshoot must be overwhelming "or the world we know, is over", as the Pacific Islands Forum pressed leaders to convert pledges into finance.

TOP STORIES

CHINA-PACIFIC

PNG minister says Taiwan office closure carries no economic cost

Papua New Guinea's foreign minister said the closure of Taiwan's office in the country will not affect the economy, the ABC reported. Port Moresby maintains diplomatic relations with Beijing, and the minister's comments are the government's first public assessment of the commercial consequences. No replacement arrangement for Taiwanese trade representation was described.

per ABC News: "PNG Foreign Minister says Taiwan office closure will not affect the economy"

AU-POLITICS

Fractured Albanese-Chalmers relationship fuels calls for a Labor reset

A treacherous economic picture has damaged the working dynamic between **Anthony Albanese** and **Jim Chalmers**, the Sydney Morning Herald reported, with factional and personality clashes inside Labor's top brass driving calls for a reset. The ABC wrote separately that few inside the government, even Labor diehards, will speak warmly of the prime minister, and that ministers see few easy policy options left.

per Sydney Morning Herald (Paul Sakkal): "The fractured Albanese-Chalmers relationship and growing calls for a Labor reset" · also ABC News: "Albanese's salad days have wilted into a long list of woe"

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Marshall Islands president warns COP31 on Paris overshoot

The President of the Marshall Islands told COP31 that the global response to overshooting the Paris Agreement temperature goal must be overwhelming "or the world we know, is over", RNZ reported. In a parallel appeal carried by PACNEWS, the president urged governments to "find money for life, not death". Pacific delegations are also resisting any weakening of 1.5 degree language in the conference's science text.

per RNZ Pacific: "Marshall Islands president gives stark warning at COP31" · also Islands Business: "Pacific urges world to turn climate commitments into action"

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Burke reworks backpacker crackdown while targeting UK visa stream

Home Affairs Minister **Tony Burke** all but confirmed the government is returning to the drawing board on its working holiday visa overhaul, saying Australia must "find a way" to reduce the number of British backpackers arriving under the free trade deal introduced in 2023, which allows UK citizens to stay up to three years without work requirements. "We can find a way to bring that back to something more sensible and in the national interest, without jeopardising the other parts of the free trade agreement," he said. In August **Anthony Albanese** ruled out imposing regional work requirements on UK backpackers.

per ABC News: "Government back to the drawing board on backpacker crackdown" · also Sydney Morning Herald (Matthew Knott): "Burke flags backpacker backdown after backlash"

OVERNIGHT

US-AUSTRALIA

Microsoft outage revives the cost question on Australian digital resilience · ABC News

Shifting Australia's dependence away from United States technology companies will require significant investment, experts told the ABC after a global Microsoft failure emptied inboxes, cancelled appointments, grounded flights and closed School of Air. Microsoft said there was no indication of a cyber attack, attributing the fault to servers failing an automated health check and cascading load. The ABC reported a top national security adviser warned of reliance on Microsoft months ago, and estimated the outage would cost Australian businesses billions of dollars.

TRADE-ECONOMY

Nvidia chief resigns after affair with alleged Chinese intelligence asset · ABC News

Jensen Huang stepped down as chief executive of Nvidia, 33 years after founding it, following revelations of an affair with a Singapore-based executive United States officials have accused of being a Chinese intelligence asset. China rejects the allegations. Nvidia shares fell *12 percent* early on Wall Street before closing 4 percent down. Nvidia-backed Australian data centre company Firmus, whose collapsed $5 billion ASX float was set to be the country's biggest listing since Telstra, now faces fresh scrutiny.

AU-DEFENSE

ACSL secures fourth Japanese drone tender · Australian Defence Magazine

Uncrewed systems maker ACSL has won a fourth Japanese drone tender, Australian Defence Magazine reported, extending a run of regional procurement wins in a segment Australian and Japanese forces are both expanding.

TRADE-ECONOMY

Northern Territory cattle flown to Kazakhstan in a new live export route · ABC News

A Kazakh buyer flew to Undoolya Station near Alice Springs, inspected the herd and took nearly 300 head, which were trucked to Melbourne, quarantined for about a month, then flown via Singapore. Producer **Ben Hayes** said Kazakhstan's government is running an initiative to build its national herd. Federal data shows Kazakhstan imported more than 1,000 head each of cattle and sheep in October.

STAT OF THE DAY

12

submarines the AUKUS Public Inquiry says Australia still needs

The independent inquiry concluded Pillar One should be cancelled while Australia still requires a credible, sovereign fleet of twelve boats.

ASPI Strategist

AUKUS WATCH

PILLARS 1 AND 2 · BREAKING DEFENSE

Admiral says AUKUS is on track and ahead of schedule in parts

An admiral told Breaking Defense that AUKUS is on track, and that some parts of the programme are running ahead of schedule. No boat count, payment figure or yard milestone was attached to the assessment in the report.

PACIFIC WIRE

NAURU · WASHINGTON POST

Nauru's president left with no political opponents in parliament

Every lawmaker in Nauru's parliament has joined the government side, the Washington Post reported, leaving the president without a formal opposition. The chamber now has no organised bloc to contest budget or legislative business.

VANUATU · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Vanuatu opposition withdraws no-confidence motion against Napat

Vanuatu's opposition bloc withdrew its motion of no confidence in Prime Minister **Jotham Napat**, Islands Business reported, ending the challenge without a floor vote.

VANUATU · ABC PACIFIC BEAT

Watchdog presses Vanuatu to publish citizenship program reports

Vanuatu's parliamentary watchdog wants government reports on the citizenship program released publicly, the ABC reported, renewing scrutiny of a scheme that has drawn repeated questions over passport and diplomatic passport issuance.

VANUATU · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Aircraft restrictions at Espiritu Santo disrupt flights

Travellers to Vanuatu have been warned of major disruption at Espiritu Santo International Airport, where strict aircraft restrictions are in force, Islands Business reported. The constraint falls on a route network already under strain from the government's aviation decisions.

FIJI · FBC NEWS

ADB signs construction contracts under Fiji bridges project

The Asian Development Bank reaffirmed its nearly five-decade partnership with Fiji's transport sector at a Fiji Roads Authority signing ceremony for construction contracts under the Critical Bridges Resilience Project. ADB Pacific representative **Matthew Rees** called the project another milestone in the bank's work with the government.

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Pacific's newest university graduates its first 140 students

The Pacific's newest university will graduate *140 students*, with Fiji's Education Minister **Aseri Radrodro** officiating, Islands Business reported. The cohort is the institution's first, adding a second degree-granting option alongside the regional university system.

FIJI · ABC PACIFIC BEAT

Fiji investigation into death in custody nears completion

The investigation into the death in custody of a Fijian crime figure is almost complete, the ABC reported. The case has become a test of police accountability procedures under the current government.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

PNGDF midshipman serves aboard Royal Navy's HMS Tamar

Midshipman **Janice Ivy Magaidimo** of the Papua New Guinea Defence Force served aboard the Royal Navy offshore patrol vessel HMS Tamar, which the Post-Courier called a milestone for women in PNG's armed forces. The embarkation is part of continuing British naval engagement in Melanesian waters.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

Wellington council restructures its executive as amalgamation and rates caps loom

Four executive roles will be disestablished and two created at Wellington City Council, cutting two jobs from an eight-person team, RNZ reported. Chief executive **Matt Prosser** cited new priorities from the Triennium Plan, Annual Plan and 2027-2037 Long Term Plan, and said "there still lies the possibility of amalgamation and the introduction of rates-capping measures", both central government reforms. The council cut 47 roles in September to save over *$4 million*.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

UN rapporteur calls the state of Indigenous rights in Australia embarrassing

A United Nations special rapporteur found Indigenous rights are "unsafe" in the hands of states and territories and warned that the failure to protect them is damaging Australia's international reputation, the ABC reported. The findings land while Canberra seeks support for its human rights standing in multilateral forums.

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Albanese answers Thunberg as Bowen defends Australia's COP31 standing

Anthony Albanese responded to **Greta Thunberg**'s criticism of Australia's net zero pace with "she's entitled to her views", the Sydney Morning Herald reported, after her appearance on the COP31 sidelines in Turkey drew more than 100 reporters and supporters. **Chris Bowen** rejected suggestions that Australia's role as a major fossil fuel exporter has damaged its standing in the negotiations.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Only four ministers delivered net savings this year

Four members of the ministry achieved net savings across their portfolios this year, the ABC found in an audit of government decisions. The tally sharpens the fiscal argument running between the prime minister's office and the treasurer as the government looks for spending restraint without new taxes.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Victorian Labor freezes farm emergency services levy before the state election

Victorian Labor will permanently freeze the Emergency Services and Volunteers Fund rate charged on farmland at 28.7 percent if re-elected this month, Agriculture Minister **Michaela Settle** said. The Coalition and One Nation have both committed to scrapping the fund, which triggered protests by farmers and Country Fire Authority volunteers facing increases of tens of thousands of dollars.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

NAB chief calls payroll tax the worst drag on productivity

NAB chief executive **Andrew Irvine** described payroll tax as "the most atrocious, abominable" factor in Australia's productivity slump and urged governments to cut spending, in comments carried by the Sydney Morning Herald and The Australian. Employment taxes sit with the states, making the complaint a federation question rather than a budget one.

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

Five green steel projects target production by 2030

At least five aspiring low-emissions steel projects across Western Australia, New South Wales and Queensland are targeting production by 2030, the ABC reported, most planning to melt scrap in electric arc furnaces powered by renewables, which proponents say cuts the carbon footprint by up to 90 percent. Conventional steelmaking accounts for *8 percent* of global greenhouse gas emissions. ANU Crawford School research fellow **Dominic Meagher** said the work "takes a long time and we don't have that much time".

TRADE-ECONOMY · RNZ

Taranaki-built ammonia tanks shipped to an Australian fertiliser plant

Three ammonia storage vessels built by Dialog Fitzroy for Hiringa Energy, each 35 metres long and 100 tonnes, moved through New Plymouth at night this week to Port Taranaki for shipment to Australia. RNZ

reported the export is being treated as evidence that the Taranaki engineering sector retains a future as gas activity contracts.

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

Air New Zealand presses for faster premium cabin seat approvals

Air New Zealand has called for faster regulatory approval of premium cabin seats, Bloomberg reported, a certification bottleneck that affects long-haul fleet refits on its North American and Asian routes.

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

Sheep prices set another national record at Naracoorte

A line of first-cross ewes sold for *$650 a head* at Naracoorte in South Australia, beating the $641 record set at Corowa in New South Wales last month. The ABC reported that a historically low national flock, run down by drought selling, is expected to keep prices elevated.

UPCOMING

NOV 2026

COP31 negotiations conclude in Turkey, with Pacific delegations pressing on finance and 1.5 degree language

The outcome text sets what adaptation and loss and damage money Pacific states can plan against next year.

NOV 2026

Victorian state election

Labor, the Coalition and One Nation have made competing commitments on the emergency services levy, and the result shapes federal Labor's reset debate.

NOV 2026

Sentence hearing for former NSW Liberal MP Rory Amon in the NSW Supreme Court

The conviction of a recent state member keeps Liberal preselection and vetting under scrutiny in a seat the party holds.

NOV 2026

Fiji police complete their investigation into a death in custody

Findings will test the government's handling of police accountability, an issue Australian and New Zealand policing programmes in Fiji intersect with.

THE WIRE

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

DEVPOLICY BLOG

One battle after another: US foreign aid after the mid-terms

Terence Wood and **Cameron Hill** argue that Democratic control of Congress alone will not rebuild United States foreign aid, drawing on the experience of aid cuts and partial restorations in Australia, Canada, New Zealand and the United Kingdom.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

ASPI STRATEGIST

China's ambassador tells Australia what to do, again

ASPI reads an op-ed by Chinese Ambassador **Liu Jinsong** in The Australian as a continuation of Beijing's effort to separate Canberra from Washington, published in the run-up to APEC.

TRADE-ECONOMY

ABC NEWS

US holds secretive talks with Myanmar regime over rare earths

Washington has been talking to a government it previously accused of genocide as it chases rare earth supply, the ABC reported, a parallel track to the critical minerals arrangements Australia has been negotiating with the United States.

THE AUSTRALIAN

PaySauce founder relocates to Melbourne to drive Australian expansion

New Zealand payroll technology founder **Asantha Wijeyeratne** has moved to Melbourne to lead PaySauce's expansion across Australia, The Australian reported, adding to the trans-Tasman flow of listed technology firms shifting their growth base west.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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